JOINT COMMISSION

Tracer Observation Form

Sterile Processing Infection Prevention

02/26/2026 03:15 PM

Site: 486045 Midwest Orthopedic Specialty Hospital

Program: Hospital

Observation Header	
Tracer Instructions: *No Instructions Provided*	
Observation Title:	
Observation Date:	
Total Completed Observations:	**Department:**
Survey Team:	**Staff Interviewed:**
Medical Staff:	**Unique Identifier:**
Location:	**Equipment Observed:**
	Contracted Service:
Note:	

Questions (* = Required)

1. In the decontamination room, is ventilation negative in relationship to adjacent areas? To determine appropriate ventilation, perform a tissue test near the bottom of the door to confirm ventilation is flowing into the room. ☐ N/A

Instructions: Mark as non-compliant if the pass-through window is open.

Compliant? ◯ Yes ◯ No | Num: _____ Den: _____

Corrective Action:

Notes:

2. Observe the use of PPE when staff cleans and decontaminates devices and/or equipment. Is the use of PPE in accordance with policy? Note: For decontamination, full PPE should be worn - impervious gown, gloves, mask, and eye protection. ☐ N/A

Compliant? ◯ Yes ◯ No | Num: _____ Den: _____

Corrective Action:

Notes:

3. Review instruments transported to decontamination. Prior to being decontaminated, are instruments pre-treated with an enzymatic detergent and free from bioburden? ☐ N/A

Instructions: Visually inspect trays of soiled instrumentation. Mark as non-compliant if there is visible blood or bioburden on instrumentation or if not sprayed with pre-treatment spray/kept moist or if instruments left in closed position/assembled.

Compliant? ◯ Yes ◯ No | Num: _____ Den: _____

Corrective Action:

Notes:

4. Observe - and discuss with associates - the use of enzymatic cleaners and detergents. Are these products used and discarded according to manufacturer's instructions and policies? Note: Ensure the appropriate concentrations are used. Typically these products must be discarded after each use unless otherwise directed by the manufacturers' instructions for use. Review dispenser calibration/quality checks with associates and process that is followed should dispenser fail. ☐ N/A

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Instructions: Review enzymatic detergent's instructions for use. Ensure the process aligns with the manufacturer-required dilution, temperature, minimum soak time, and frequency of discarding

Compliant? ◯ Yes ◯ No	Num: _____ Den: _____
Corrective Action:	
Notes:	

5. Review the process for the care of cleaning brushes. Are associates able to identify which brushes are single use vs multiple use? Are multi-use brushes run through the washer/disinfector at least daily and discarded when frayed? ☐ N/A

Compliant? ◯ Yes ◯ No	Num: _____ Den: _____
Corrective Action:	
Notes:	

6. Instruments are thoroughly decontaminated according to manufacturer's instructions for use? Can associate pull a requested IFU for review during tracer? ☐ N/A

Compliant? ◯ Yes ◯ No	Num: _____ Den: _____
Corrective Action:	
Notes:	

7. Water quality used for the final instrument rinse aligns with instrument manufacturer's instructions for use ☐ N/A

Instructions: Instructions for use may require treated water, specifically reverse osmosis, deionized water, or distilled water. If water quality is not specified, refer to AAMI TIR34

Compliant? ◯ Yes ◯ No	Num: _____ Den: _____
Corrective Action:	
Notes:	

8. Ultrasonic cleaning fluid is changed at intervals specified by the manufacturer ☐ N/A

Instructions: At least daily and if visibly soiled. Some manufacturer's may require changing fluid after each cycle or after a specific number of cycles.

Compliant? ◯ Yes ◯ No	Num: _____ Den: _____
Corrective Action:	
Notes:	

9. Quality testing on automated washer/disinfectors and ultrasonic washers is performed daily and all results are documented. All out of range test results have corrective action documented. ☐ N/A

Instructions: Quality testing includes a washer indicator such as Verify, All Clear, or Tosi and daily cavitation testing for ultrasonic cleaners

Compliant? ◯ Yes ◯ No	Num: _____ Den: _____
Corrective Action:	
Notes:	

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10. Automated washers are clean and in good working order. Can associates review the expected cleaning schedule for the automated washer(s)? ☐ N/A

Instructions: Strainers should be clean and free of visible debris. Spray arms should be checked at least daily to ensure they are free turning and not clogged

Compliant? ◯ Yes ◯ No	Num: _____ Den: _____
Corrective Action:	
Notes:	

11. Water treatment systems used to prepare final rinse water (e.g. RO systems or DI systems) have current preventive maintenance performed and all quality control is within range. Can associates verbalize indications/signs that final rinse water is not treated water? ☐ N/A

Compliant? ◯ Yes ◯ No	Num: _____ Den: _____
Corrective Action:	
Notes:	

12. If reusable critical instruments and devices are not sterilized on site, are they decontaminated prior to transportation? ☐ N/A

Compliant? ◯ Yes ◯ No	Num: _____ Den: _____
Corrective Action:	
Notes:	

13. Observe attire. Is surgical attire worn in accordance with policy? ☐ N/A

Instructions: For assembly, sterilization, and sterile storage, at a minimum, all staff should be in scrubs with hair coverings and beard coverings (if applicable)

Compliant? ◯ Yes ◯ No	Num: _____ Den: _____
Corrective Action:	
Notes:	

14. Instruments are thoroughly dried and visually inspected prior to packaging ☐ N/A

Instructions: Lumened instruments should be dried with instrument air. Lint free cloths should be used to dry external surfaces of instruments. Staff should be able to verbalize that instruments are inspected for pitting, rust, and retained bioburden as part of the assembly process.

Compliant? ◯ Yes ◯ No	Num: _____ Den: _____
Corrective Action:	
Notes:	

15. Staff have access to tools/equipment to facilitate visual inspection of instruments ☐ N/A

Instructions: Lighted magnification should be present at all assembly stations and ability to verify sharpness of instruments. Departments may have access to a borescope to inspect lumened instruments, and if none are available, associates can review process for inspecting lumened instruments.

Compliant? ◯ Yes ◯ No	Num: _____ Den: _____
Corrective Action:	

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Notes:

16. Instruments are appropriately wrapped/packaged for sterilization. Examples: Package system selected is compatible with the sterilization process being performed, hinged instruments are open, and instruments are disassembled if indicated by the manufacturer. ☐ N/A

Instructions: Peel pack seams are not wrinkled or folded. No writing on the paper side of peel packs or on blue wrap. Tip protectors and instrument hinge separators are used when appropriate.

Compliant? ◯ Yes ◯ No | Num: _____ Den: _____

Corrective Action:

Notes:

17. If double peel packs are used for sterilization, observe items that have been packaged in this manner. Is this method validated by the manufacturer and/or evidence-based guidelines and are the instruments packaged appropriately? Note: Inner pack should not be folded. ☐ N/A

Compliant? ◯ Yes ◯ No | Num: _____ Den: _____

Corrective Action:

Notes:

18. Sterilized items do not exceed the weight limits per sterilization wrap manufacturer's instructions for use ☐ N/A

Instructions: Rigid containerized sets may not exceed 25 lbs. Weight limits for wrapped items and peel packed items vary per manufacturer's IFU

Compliant? ◯ Yes ◯ No | Num: _____ Den: _____

Corrective Action:

Notes:

19. Instruments are sterilized in accordance with manufacturer's instructions for use. Review with associates process for validating that cycle type is met. ☐ N/A

Instructions: Sterilization parameters include: sterilization cycle type, sterilization temperature, sterilization time and dry time. All load contents are validated for being compatible with the same cycle parameters prior to sterilization.

Compliant? ◯ Yes ◯ No | Num: _____ Den: _____

Corrective Action:

Notes:

20. Are sterile packs labeled with the sterilizer used, the cycle or load number, and the date of sterilization? ☐ N/A

Compliant? ◯ Yes ◯ No | Num: _____ Den: _____

Corrective Action:

Notes:

21. For dynamic air removal-type sterilizers, is a Bowie-Dick test performed each day the sterilizer is used to verify efficacy of air removal? ☐ N/A

Compliant? ◯ Yes ◯ No | Num: _____ Den: _____

Corrective Action:

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Notes:

22. Are biologic indicators (BIs) used in every load? Review the documentation logs to verify that the practice is performed in accordance with policy. ☐ N/A

Instructions: Challenge packs containing biologic indicators should be placed in the most challenging location within the sterilizer (e.g. closest to the drain). Associates can speak to the definition of a "challenge pack." (for individual completing tracer; challenge packs may be flash pack or rigid container). BIs should be compatible with the sterilization cycle type and parameters used.

Compliant? ◯ Yes ◯ No | Num: _____ Den: _____

Corrective Action:

Notes:

23. Are logs for each sterilizer cycle current and complete? ☐ N/A

Compliant? ◯ Yes ◯ No | Num: _____ Den: _____

Corrective Action:

Notes:

24. Review the biological indicator (BI) logs from the most recent 7 days. Is all documentation complete and accurate? ☐ N/A

Instructions: Lot numbers of BI and controls match and are recorded. BI and controls are read within the timeframe recommended by the manufacturer. Sterilization cycle parameters align with BI used. BIs are run for each cycle type used: pre-vacuum, gravity and low temperature sterilization. Ensure all supplies used are not expired.

Compliant? ◯ Yes ◯ No | Num: _____ Den: _____

Corrective Action:

Notes:

25. If load contents must be released before the results of the BI are available, early release is documented. Associates can speak to time sterilized instruments should be allowed to cool prior to release. If instruments are released early, form is completed. ☐ N/A

Instructions: Associates can verbalize cool time of 30 minutes minimum including method used for indicating cool time.

Compliant? ◯ Yes ◯ No | Num: _____ Den: _____

Corrective Action:

Notes:

26. Observe the sterile storage rooms. Review records and the processes used to ensure that recommended humidity levels and temperatures are maintained. Do records indicate that humidity and temperature have been maintained in accordance with policy? ☐ N/A

Instructions: Humidity between 20-60%. Temperature between 68-75 degrees Fahrenheit.

Compliant? ◯ Yes ◯ No | Num: _____ Den: _____

Corrective Action:

Notes:

27. Observe the sterile storage rooms. Are sterile items stored in a manner to prevent compromised sterility? ☐ N/A

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Instructions: Examples: protected by dust covers when indicated, a reasonable distance from the floor, impervious bottom shelves. Rigid containers are not stored on top of wrapped sets. Items are positioned so that packaging is not crushed, bent, compressed, or punctured.

Compliant? ◯ Yes ◯ No	Num: _____ Den: _____
Corrective Action:	
Notes:	

28. All items in storage maintain event-related sterility and are not expired ☐ N/A

Instructions: For event-related sterility instruments should have no evidence of moisture, compromised packaging, or external indicators without appropriate color changes. Process should exist for auditing older sets that have not been used to ensure instrument integrity has been maintained. Process should exist to ensure storage times do not exceed the manufacturer's instructions for use

Compliant? ◯ Yes ◯ No	Num: _____ Den: _____
Corrective Action:	
Notes:	

29. Corrugated cardboard is not present in any sterile storage area ☐ N/A

Compliant? ◯ Yes ◯ No	Num: _____ Den: _____
Corrective Action:	
Notes:	

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